



ESOL Nexus professional development

Managing your own

Continuing Professional Development



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Introduction

ESOL Nexus professional development modules are intended to help teachers to develop in their role in a range of contexts. They have been written by expert practitioners and quality assured by a wider team. We hope that you will find this module useful. For other professional development opportunities, see

<https://esol.britishcouncil.org/content/teachers/staff-room/continuing-professional-development>

This module is about developing and recording your own continuing professional development (CPD) to help you progress as a teacher. CPD can include a wide range of activities that will improve your practice and have an impact on your development as a teacher. This in turn should improve the learner experience.

ESOL teachers working in prison settings may have different requirements for CPD than those working in FE settings, for example, dealing with difficult behaviour. They may also lack resources that are appropriate for the learners in the prison context and have limited access to ICT.

You may be considering your own subject skills, for example, how you become a better ESOL teacher by keeping up to date with developments from exam boards or sharing resources and ideas with colleagues. It could also be about exploring new approaches to teaching and learning, perhaps trying out different group work strategies or how you can differentiate learning for a group of learners in a prison setting with minimal resources.

The module focuses on how to manage your own professional development as an ESOL teacher working in a prison environment. It introduces different models to allow you to consider approaches that will work well for you and your learners and help you improve both your classroom practice and subject knowledge.

Using this module

- While you can work through the module on your own and at your own pace, you will get greater benefits by working through it together with colleagues.
- If you are looking at the pdf on your computer you can type your reflections into the boxes provided, and save your progress for the next time you return to the module.
- There are links to videos embedded in the activities and suggested answers for activities at the end of the unit, as appropriate. There is also list with further reading related to the content.



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Finding out more about CPD

This step will help you to answer the following questions:

- What is continuing professional development and why do it?
- What training and development have I done already towards my CPD?
- How can I decide on a focus for my CPD?

Step 1

What is CPD?

As professional teachers we all need to stay current and develop our skills and keep up to date with practice, whether in teaching and learning approaches or specialist language teaching skills.

Activity 1: What does CPD mean to you?

Write some ideas below:

.....

.....

.....

.....

Activity 2: Read the following two definitions of CPD.

Continuing Professional Development (CPD) is the means by which professionals maintain and enhance their knowledge and skills. The world is moving ever faster so on-going CPD is essential to support you in your current role as well as helping you with career progression. CPD is all about upgrading knowledge, skills and capabilities to remain effective and compliant.

You are already likely to be participating in learning activities which contribute towards your Continuing Professional Development without realising it. Almost everything that improves your knowledge and skills is considered as CPD.

www.cips.org

Step 1a

‘Continuing professional development means maintaining, improving and broadening relevant knowledge and skills in your subject specialism and your teaching and training, so that it has a positive impact on practice and the learner experience... It is the critical reflection on learning experiences and activities that improve practice and demonstrate continuing development as a teacher or trainer.’

Institute for Learning, 2009, *Guidelines for Continuing Professional Development*

Considering these two definitions of CPD make a list of 3 / 4 things you could do to help you:

1. Upgrade your knowledge and skills in your ESOL subject specialism.

2. Improve and broaden your approach to teaching and learning of ESOL in prison.

Step 1a

Activity 3

Now you have begun to consider further what CPD is, clarify your own definition of what CPD is from your initial ideas and from the definitions you have considered.

My definition of CDP is...

Identifying activity for your CPD

Activity 4

Have a look at this wordle that is made up of ideas for the content for teachers' CPD. Circle four activities you think would be useful to prioritise as part of your CPD. Are there any activities on the list that you didn't expect to find or hadn't previously considered as possible CPD? Research any new ideas online.

examination-review
professional-learning curriculum
attending-external-training
reading
designing-action-research
observation gaining-further-qualifications briefings
adapting-technologies-for-a-prison-setting
peer-review
innovative-lesson-planning conferences
peer-coaching journals updating sharing-teaching-ideas events
networking-with-colleagues



Watch video

My top four CPD activities

1.
2.
3.
4.

Teachers and trainers talk about what constitutes their CPD. Watch this video made by the Society of Education and Training of teachers who work in the education and skills sector talking about ways they have kept abreast of their CPD.

<https://vimeo.com/28001837>

Step 1b

Activity 5

Think about some of your recent teaching experiences. What activities have you done to improve and update your skills for your teaching role in prison? You may have worked alone, for example reviewed and changed lesson plans to incorporate active learning. You may have collaborated with other members of your team to address a particular issue or compare experience of a new approach.

Table A

What are four things you have done to help improve and update your practice?

1.
2.
3.
4.

Table B

What difference did they make to your learners, personal practice or your teaching team?

1.
2.
3.
4.

Look carefully at what you have written in Table B. Many institutions require staff to keep a record of their CPD. This table could help you complete yours. We would recommend that you keep a record of your CPD, whether or not your institution requires it.

Deciding on a focus for your CPD

CPD Organisational or individual practice?

So far we have explored the different constituents of CPD and its importance to you as a professional teacher.

When planning you need to also consider the important link between your personal needs and interests and those of your ESOL learners, your ESOL department and the prison education teams.

Who is responsible for your CPD?

You need to take responsibility for your own professional development to ensure that as a professional you keep up to date with ongoing changes. Your individual CPD allows you to update your subject knowledge and ESOL specialism. You may have clear ideas to progress your professionalism or you may identify these needs with the support of your education manager or colleagues.

Your organisation should also play a part in supporting your development through appraisal, team working with colleagues, enabling or encouraging you to attend training courses and conferences.

The teaching practitioner is at the centre of the CPD process and responsible for reflecting on practice and identifying personal development needs. Professional development plans should clearly articulate the needs of the teaching practitioner, setting measurable objectives that reflect the teaching context and synthesise with the needs of the employer.

IfL 2009 Review of CPD

Step 1c

Activity 6

Consider recent training and development opportunities that your employer has provided or enabled you to attend. This could include induction, team meetings, access to professional journals or peer activities. If you have not been offered any opportunities note any you have done in your own time.

What did you do?	How did you feedback information?	How did it help your organisation?

Effectively developed and managed CPD can have a significant and positive impact for learners, practitioners, teams and the organisation.

(IfL Review of CPD 2008-9) 2009b p20

Benefits of CPD

There are many benefits you and your team / department in prison may gain from your ongoing professional development.

Activity 7

Have a look at the benefits of completing CPD for both you and your organisation. Consider the statements and rank them in the order you consider to be most important to those you think are least important under the headings below.

develop your professionalism
helps you reach career goals
builds your self-confidence
builds staff morale and motivation
ensures skilled professional teachers
supports appraisals /
staff development review

allows you to support your peers
improve your performance in
your current job
helps you become a more effective
team member
helps support change in the workplace
improves morale and staff motivation
supports higher workplace performance

individuals

organisations

Step 1c



Read

Activity 8

Read the professional standards for teachers and trainers in Education and Training . This document outlines the expectations of a professional teacher working in our sector.

How do the activities you have noted in section 1 link to the standards. Match some of the training you have undertaken to 3 of the standards.



1.
2.
3.

Step 1c

Becoming a reflective practitioner

Step 2

This step will help you to answer the following questions:

- What is reflective practice?
- How can reflective practice help me develop my teaching practice? How and when should I reflect?
- Is there a model I can select to help me?

An effective way of developing your own practice is through careful and considered reflection. Reflective practice requires you to be able to critically examine aspects of your teaching role. It can be done formally and informally.

Formal reflection draws on research and theory, which can provide guidance and a framework to support your practice. An informal process would involve self - questioning and developing a greater awareness of what is happening in classrooms during teaching and learning. Eliciting and acting on feedback from your learners on different activities or approaches can provide you with further insights and help develop the critical thinking skills learners need to take greater control of their learning.

Using reflective practice



Watch video

‘Reflection is an important human activity in which people recapture their experience, think about it, mull over and evaluate it. It is this working with experience that is important in learning’¹.

In this video Dylan Wiliam draws on the wisdom of many scholars, ancient and modern, to reinforce the need for consistent reflection on teaching and learning.

Activity 9

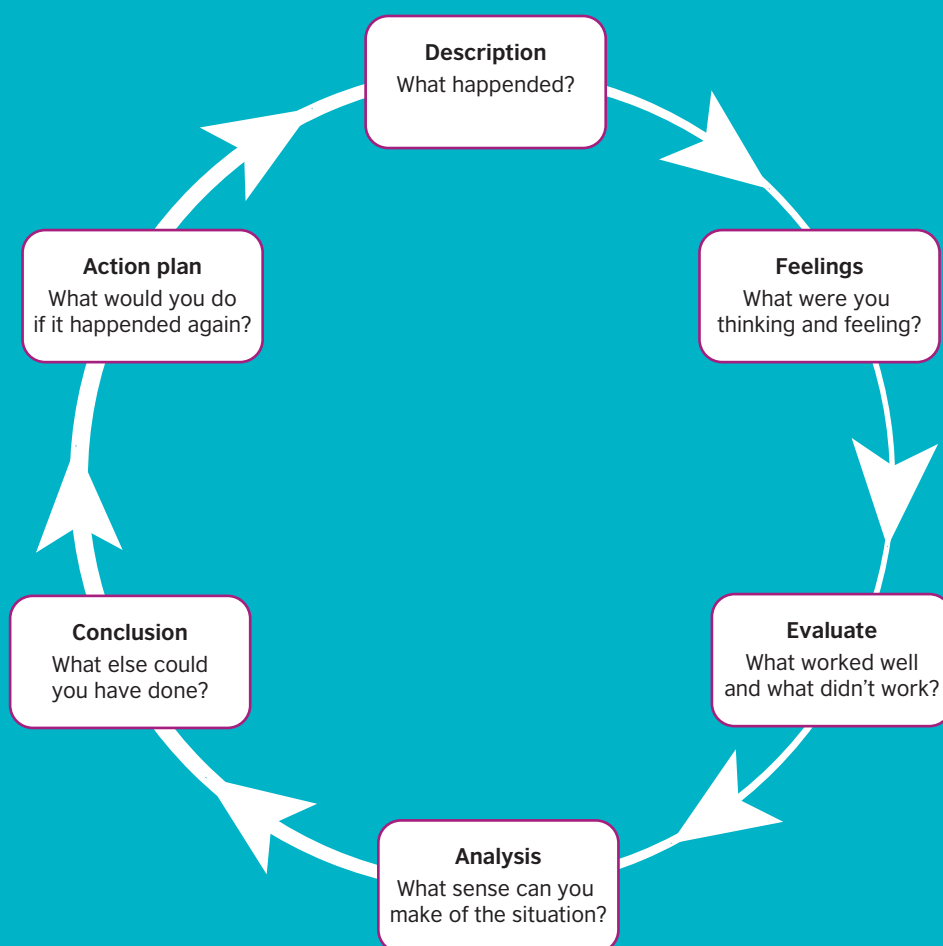
Which of the quotes on reflective practice in the video most resonates for you?

What does reflective practice mean for you? Jot down your ideas. Share some of the quotes with your colleagues. Do they agree or differ?

Most of us learn from experiences. If we don’t reflect on that experience and think about how we could do better next time, we don’t learn from it.

¹ Boud, D., Keogh, R. & Walker, D., 1985, Reflection: Turning Experience into Learning. London: Kogan Page. p 43

This reflective cycle devised by Professor Graham Gibbs¹ is particularly relevant to action research .



¹Gibbs, G, 1988, Learning by Doing, FEU

Activity 10: Using a reflective cycle.

Think about a recent classroom incident or event, for example a learning activity that did not go well and complete the box below with your reflections.

Description (what happened?)	
Feeling (how did you feel?)	
Evaluation (what was good or bad about the situation?)	
Analysis (so what? what if? why?)	
Conclusion (what else could you have done?).	
Action plan (what will you do next time?)	

Step 2a

Reflecting on my practice

Reflective practitioners constantly review and evaluate their lessons. Recording what went well and what did not at the end of each session is essential continuous improvement. For this reason we ask learners to monitor their own progress and support them with formative assessment checks. It also helps to analyse lessons in more depth to ensure that our teaching is balanced and inclusive.

Step 2b

Activity 11

Use these questions to reflect and analyse a recent lesson:

1. How much time (per cent) was tutor talk?	%
2. How much time (per cent) was learner talk?	%
3. Did every learner get a chance to speak?	%
4. How much time (%) was spent on Speaking Listening Reading Writing	% % % %
5. Where did you sit or stand in relation to your learners during the session?	%
6. How much did you move around the room or space, and for what purpose?	%
7. How many learners did you address by name?	%
8. How much individual time did you spend with learners needing help?	%
9. Did you ask them individually or in small groups to undertake independent work or practice, either in or after the session?	%
10. How well did you feel your differentiation strategies worked?	%
11. Which of the following teaching strategies did you use? Whole class Small group work Pair work Individual work	yes no yes no yes no yes no
12. What resources or teaching aids did you use? (smartboard, whiteboard, worksheets, video, audio, handouts, CD ROM, Virtual Campus)	%

[Click for feedback.](#)

After checking the feedback, consider what changes you might make to future sessions, and how, to ensure that learners have opportunities:

- to learn in a variety of ways; and
- to play an active role in learning in each session.

Changes I made include:

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

Activity 12

Read British Council, 2012, *Going Forward: Continuing Professional Development for English Language Teachers in the UK*.

This booklet, a CPD framework for teachers to consider at various stages in their careers, will help you establish where you are in your professional development in your subject specialist area and decide on your next steps.

What stage do you think you are at?

Explore the 'priority focus for your CPD activity at this stage' section.

Which of the suggestions would help you develop your professional skills? How?

1.
2.
3.



Read

Recording my CPD

Recording your CPD is crucial, as it provides a lasting and progressive record of your development activity and evidences your professionalism. A CPD record is useful when applying for promotion or new teaching posts. It may be a requirement of the organisation you work for.

Your own record could be in the form of a diary, typed up on your computer, an online record or stored on a mobile device. There is no right or wrong way to do it. However, it should record not only the CPD activity, but also the impact it had. This may demonstrate the changes it made to your practice and how that affected learners. It may explore how you supported colleagues or made a positive change to teaching and learning in general.

A SWOT chart can provide a good starting point for CPD.

S – strengths **W** – weaknesses **O** – opportunities **T** – threats

Strengths

I have a good knowledge of ESOL courses and curriculum on offer

I plan my lessons well and can differentiate learning for learners

I use active learning techniques as often as possible

Weaknesses

I find some aspects of behaviour management difficult

We don't have many good resources in the department and haven't yet collaborated or shared resources

I find working in a prison stressful

Opportunities

I work in a strong team and my colleagues are very supportive

I have been able to do some research into effective teaching techniques that has enlivened my teaching

Threats

There will be funding cuts in the coming year and I worry about my job

New exams will be introduced in September and I am not familiar with the changes

My head of department is leaving and it may be difficult to adapt to someone new

Step 2c

Activity 13:

Think about your strength, weaknesses, opportunities and threats and write up your own SWOT chart

Strengths

Weaknesses

Opportunities

Threats

Your SWOT provides a good foundation for your appraisal or preparation for your Personal Development Plan (PDP) or Record (PDR) that you will more than likely have to complete annually in the workplace.

Action research as CPD

This step will help you to answer the following questions:

- What is action research?
- How can I use action research as an approach to my CPD?
- What classroom practice can be improved through action research?
- How can I plan and carry out action research?

Action research is well placed in the classroom where teachers can solve the puzzles and problems that they face regularly with their learners in their situation. By reflecting on what is happening in the class and in their interaction with learners in the learning process, teachers can begin to pose key questions that they can resolve through their own research.

Both learners and colleagues can be involved in the process. This section explores practitioner led action research and explores a problem posed by a teacher and its resolution. It encourages you to design and develop answers to your own classroom problems and questions.

Step 3

Using action research



Read

This article from the University of Plymouth considers why and how teachers can use action research as an integral part of their CPD. Read and answer the question below.

Activity 14

What is action research in education?

[Click for suggested answers.](#)

Extension activity: The Education and Training Foundation have positively supported Practitioner Led Action Research (PLAR) which encourages teachers to carry out small scale action research projects that are firmly embedded in classroom practice. Find out more at:

<https://practitionerledactionresearch2014.wordpress.com/>

The important aspects of PLAR are

- that it small scale and addresses a real issue for the teacher
- the teacher decides on the question / problem to be addressed
- the method and approach to the research are controlled by the practitioner
- The process generates change and improves classroom practice

Step 3a

**Read**

Activity 15: Exploring action research

Read this British Council article that considers questions that arise when we undertake action research.

Next, create some bullet points to highlight how you think action research can help one aspect of your practice or the outcome for your learners.

-
-
-
-
-
-

Step 3a

Action research at work



Watch video

This section explores how action research worked for one teacher, Andrea Robles, as an example you could use to design and try out classroom based research of your own. Watch this webinar on exploratory action research:



Andrea was unsure whether she was ending her lessons effectively. Her research question was: 'When I end my lessons, am I doing it right?' To find out more about her practice, she designed a small research project:

Activity 16

Identify the steps Andrea took to explore the problem and write them in the box below.

.....

.....

.....

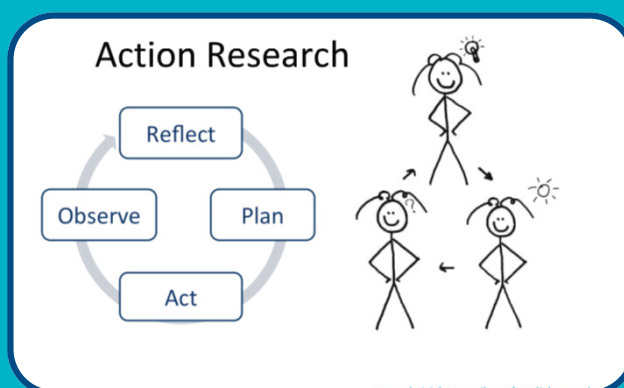
.....

[Click for answers.](#)

Step 3b

Activity 17: Now plan your own research activity

First identify an issue. It may be based on feedback from an observation of your teaching, comments by your learners or something that you wish to change. You could use this simple cycle Andrea devised to help you with your planning:



Think carefully about your learners and your teaching and learning activities. What would you like to change or improve in your teaching? You could reflect on an approach that has not gone so well or where you perceive you could do better. Keep the subject small and manageable, just like Andrea did. Complete the sentences below.

In my teaching, I would like to improve

Something that may make a difference is

I am unhappy about

I would like to change

Step 3b

Reflect on the four things you would like to change and choose one to work on:

Stage 1 – Reflect

My research question:

.....

.....

Stage 2 – Plan

Where can I find out more?

.....

Who can help me?

.....

Stage 3 – Act

What will I try out in my classroom?

.....

Stage 4 - How did it go?

What did I do differently?

.....

What did I learn?

.....

What did my learners think about the changes?

.....

What my colleague/s did my colleagues think?

.....

How will I incorporate my learning in my practice?

.....

Sharing your action research

Working with others adds to the effectiveness of action research.

Colleagues can act as sounding boards; compare activities; observe your teaching and offer insights. Building a learning community that shares expertise would be of benefit teachers, learners and their employers but needs commitment and support.

Activity 18

Answer the following questions and share this with colleagues, perhaps as part of a staff meeting.

What I explored:

.....

.....

What I learned:

.....

.....

How I will use it to develop my professional practice:

.....

.....

Other ideas for my action research that I would find useful:

.....

.....

How we could do a team action research project.

.....

.....



Read

The report IfL/157 Group , 2012, Great teaching and Learning, summarises the outcomes of a workshop aiming *‘to translate the teaching ‘gold standard’ into reality – by considering the factors that ‘boost’ or ‘block’ its happening, and then .. generate some real ideas for the future....’*

Activity 20

Read this extract from the report’s conclusion that reinforces this module’s messages and underlines the value of building learning communities.

....the teaching profession must take more charge of its own destiny – enabled to develop genuine communities, where good practice, experiments and research evidence are shared and ideas are fostered. This will mean that more risks are taken, but teachers who are open, who plan their own development and who share ideas are more likely to be inspirational in the way that they and we want them to be.

Jot down any barriers or difficulties you envisage. Add ideas for overcoming these.

Barrier / difficulty	Possible solution

Step 3c

Activity 21

Have a look at the wordle below. Use it as a starting point to work with other teachers in your team. Next, work through the questions to find a focus on a common area for development.



What teaching challenges do you share?

.....

What specifically are you hoping to achieve?

.....

What do you want to find out more about?

.....

What will you try out and with which group of learners?

.....

What support do you need and from whom?

.....

How will you evaluate your action research (e.g. feedback from learners, self- assessment, evaluation, peer review and observation)?

.....

Reflection

In this module you have considered teaching ESOL one-to-one. Now spend a short time reflecting on what you have learnt.

Stage 1: What?

Consider what you have learnt and wish to remember about:

- Deciding the content of your CPD
- Developing and extending ideas for your self development
- Recording your CPD

Stage 2: So what?

Reflect by considering your thoughts and feelings about the content in the module and making some notes.

- What do you feel about reflective practice?
- Have there been any changes in your thinking about reflection and learning?
- How will what you have learnt affect the people you teach?

Stage 3: Now what?

How can you apply what you have learnt in this module to your own teaching context?

- How will you apply your learning from the module?
- What will you do in the classroom that you didn't do before?
- Write up a time bound action plan and share it with a colleague so you stick with it

Suggested answers to activities

Activity 11

1. While this will vary from session to session you should aim to minimise teacher talk to give learners as much time as possible to practise their developing skills, particularly speaking in a supportive environment.
2. Learners should be doing most of the talking, but this should be purposeful in terms of planned learning outcomes..
3. Effective learning is encouraged by active participation. Make sure that everyone particularly the lower-level/less confident, gets a chance to talk:e.g. set ground rules, drill, use small group work, nominate learners to respond in plenaries
4. Carefully consider the balance of activities. Speaking/ listening activities are vitally important and can be overtaken by individual reading/writing .Some learners may demand writing tasks to avoid the challenges of speaking in class.
5. If you tend to stay at the front, your learners will always have the same perspective, and so will you! This is most significant when teaching an activity-based subject.
6. If you seem rooted to your chair, learners may find it more difficult to ask you questions. For some this may reinforce a poor school experience. Avoid ' prowling', learners may feel uncomfortable. Are you checking or supporting?
7. A name acknowledges individuality which is easily undermined in prison. Learners should always choose how they wish to be known. Using names when asking questions allows you to manage over-eager learners who may, consciously or unconsciously, be dominant. It.
8. While giving the more time to lower level learners is justifiable you need to make sure that others do not feel neglected by effective planning and differentiation. It's wise to monitor this closely and include one-two-one time to check progress at regular intervals.
- 9 At its most effective, language learnt in class is relevant to everyday needs but some learners might need more encouragement and structure. Set manageable cell work in addition to practising language they need outside class.
10. Regular learning checks (formative assessment) will help you monitor progress and evaluate the effectiveness of your differentiated activities. Take this further by doing the CPD module on differentiation.
<https://esol.britishcouncil.org/content/teachers/teaching-english-work/offender-learning/differentiating-learning-prison>
- 11/12. To maintain interest, meet individual needs and cater for learning differences and preferences, it is vital to use a variety of strategies and resources in every session. Learners benefit from both individual and group approaches.

Activity 14

- Action research is a process of enquiry. It is research into practice carried out by those involved in that practice.
 - It involves teachers forming their own questions in order to study aspects of their own professional practice.
 - It is most likely an enquiry into the effectiveness of teaching and learning – carried out by the teacher with their learners.
 - Action research is usually research initiated to solve an immediate problem
- or
- a reflective process of progressive problem solving led by teachers working with others in teams or as part of a "community of practice" to improve the way they address issues and solve problems in their teaching and learning environment.

Activity 16

- asked colleagues about their practice
- surfed the web for information and ideas
- asked a colleague to observe her endings
- compared what she was doing to her findings from others/ information
- planned and tried out different lesson endings
- asked a colleague to observe her to note changes
- asked her learners about the new endings
- shared her findings via a poster report

Further reading and websites

These are some of the most useful resources available to support practitioner research. They are available free of charge online and from Learning Connections.

Horsman, J. & Norton, M., 1999, *A Framework to Encourage and Support Involvement in Adult Literacy Research in Practice in Canada*. Ottawa: National Literacy Secretariat.

<http://www.nald.ca/library/research/framework/framework.pdf>

MacLachlan, K., Hall, S., Tett, L. and Crowther, J., 2006, Practitioner-Led Action Research in Adult Literacies Project: 'New Ways to Engage New Learners'. Glasgow, Communities Scotland.

<http://www.gov.scot/Publications/2009/12/15095637/16>

McNiff, J. Jean McNiff's Action Research Website.

<http://www.jeanmcniff.com>

National Research and Development Centre, 2008, *Practitioner-led Research Initiative*.

<http://www.nrdc.org.uk/content.asp?CategoryID=512&ArticleID=437>

National Center for the Study of Adult Learning and Literacy, 2005, Practitioner Research Training Guide <http://www.ncsall.net/?id=1144>

Quigley, B.A. & Norton, M., 2002, *"It simply makes us better": Learning from Literacy Research in Practice Networks in the UK, Australia and the United States. A Resource for Literacy Research in Practice in Canada*. Edmonton: The Learning Centre. www.nald.ca/library/research/simply/simply.pdf

Further reading and websites

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<http://www.ncsall.net/fileadmin/resources/research/report22.pdf>

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www.gov.scot/resource/doc/296518/0092153.pdf